Red, White and Bruised – A Program

with poems by Francis Scott Key, , Linda Hogan, Angelica Maria Aguilera and Lydia Mason

Star Spangled Banner by Francis Scott Key (excerpt)

(Singing) O say can you see, by the dawn's early light,
What so proudly we hail'd at the twilight's last
gleaming. . .
And the rocket's red glare, the bomb bursting in air,
Gave proof through the night that our flag was still
there,
O say does that star-spangled banner yet wave
O'er the land of the free and the home of the brave?

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Francis Scott Key
Weblink:
https://amhistory.si.edu/starspangledbanner/pdf/ssb_lyrics.pdf
First Published: Baltimore Patriot and The American (newspapers) Sept 20, 1814
Adopted as the US National Anthem on March 3, 1931

4NG Fanatics

Dear America by Lydia Mason

Dear America,

I think we need to talk.

The constitution of this relationship isn't working out.

I think we need an amendment.

(except – continues as final poem in this program)

INTRODUCTION

These poems expose the gap between America's promises of freedom and its history of oppression. They highlight the emotional weight carried by marginalized communities: immigrants struggling with language and belonging, Native peoples enduring forced removal and generational trauma, and citizens whose protests are met with violence rather than justice.

So many people today are questioning the meaning of the "American Dream" and challenging the systems that exclude and silence. Yet despite our nation's painful history and protests still occurring today, we must hold on to a determined hope. A hope for a more honest, inclusive America -- one that lives up to its ideals of freedom, justice, and true belonging for all.

Red, White and Bruised with Trail of Tears: Our Removal by Linda Hogan; The Star Spanglish Banner by Angelica Maria Aguilera and Dear America by Lydia Mason

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

4NG Fanatics

Trail of Tears: Our Removal by Linda Hogan

With lines unseen the land was broken.
When surveyors came, we knew
what the prophet had said was true,
this land with unseen lines would be taken.
So, you who live there now,
don't forget to love it, thank it
the place that was once our forest,
our ponds, our mosses,
the swamplands with birds and more lowly creatures.
As for us, we walked into the military strength of
hunger
and war for that land we still dream.
As the ferry crossed the distance,
or as the walkers left behind their loved ones,
think how we took with us our cats and kittens,
the puppies we loved. We were innocent of what we
faced,
along the trail. We took clothing, dishes,
thinking there would be something to start a new life,
believing justice lived in the world,
and the horses, so many,
one by one stolen, taken by the many thieves
So have compassion for that land at least.
Every step we took was one away from the songs,
old dances, memories, some of us dark and not
speaking English,
some of us white, or married to the dark, or children
of translators
the half-white, all of us watched by America, all of us
longing for trees for shade, homing, rooting,
even more for food along the hunger way.
You would think those of us born later
would fight for justice, for peace,
for the new land, it's trees being taken.
You would think
the struggle would be over
between the two worlds in this place
that is now our knowledge,
our new belonging, our being,
and we'd never again care for the notion of maps
or American wars, or the god of their sky,
thinking of those things we were forced to leave
behind,

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

living country, stolen home,
the world measured inch by inch, mile by mile,
hectares, all measurements, even the trail of our
tears.
With all the new fierce light, heat, drought
the missing water, you'd think
in another red century, the old wisdom
might exist if we considered enough
that even before the new beliefs
we were once whole,
but now our bodies and minds remain
the measured geography.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Linda Hogan
Book: Dark. Sweet
ISBN: 978-1566893510
Publisher: Coffee House Press
Date (Month/Year): July 2014

The Star Spanglish Banner by Angelica Maria Aguilera

(singing) Oh say can you see . . .
(speaking) Miguel wants to learn the star-spangled
banner.
Miguel was the last fourth grader to

4NG Fanatics

Migrate into my English as a second language course,
And is the first to raise his hand for every question.
But Miguel views letters in a different way than most
Because there are many words in Spanish
That do not exist in English.

(singing) And the rocket's red glare . . .
We watched our home
Bursting in air
(speaking) He learns how to pack them in a suitcase
and forget
Because many phrases translate backwards
When crossing over from Spanish to English.
Throughout the whole song, he tends to say things
In the wrong order so when I asked him to sing
The second verse it sounds like

(singing) Gave proof through the night
That the flag was still theirs . . .
(speaking) They say music is deeply intertwined
With how we remember.
Miguel hears his mother's accent being mocked
And learns the word "shame."

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

Hears his mother's weeping

And learns the word “sacrifice.”

What does the word “America” mean?

What does the word “dream” mean?

I say two words with the same meaning are

What we call synonyms.

You could say America is a dream,

Something we all feel silly for believing in.

(singing) And for whom does that

Star-spangled banner yet wave . . .

(speaking) He says teach me how to say Bandera.

Teach me how to say star.

Teach me how to hide my country

Behind the consonants that

Do not get pronounced.

In my tongue we do not

Pronounce the letter H.

Home is not a sound my voice

Knows how to make.

It's strange what our memories hold on to.

It's strange what makes it over the border

4NG Fanatics

From the left side of the brain

But what our minds do not let us forget

How an accent is just a mother tongue

That refuses to let her child go.

The language barrier is a 74-mile wall

Lodged in the back of Miguel's throat.

The bodies of words so easily lost in the translation.

Give back the land and set us free

And let us make a home for the brave.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Angelica Maria Aguilera
Weblink: **https://www.poemhunter.com/poem/the-star-spanglish-banner-by-angelica-maria-aguilera-2/**
ISBN: On-Line Transcript
Publisher: Poem Hunter.com
Date (Month/Year): Nov 2019

Dear America by Lydia Mason (continued)

Dear America, I think we need to talk . . .

On our first date you promised I would always be free

to express myself.

But when I told you that I hated the way you

looked in your racism

You threw tear gas in my eyes and convinced me I was

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

only crying because of your beauty
On date two, you said I would always be protected
around you
But you broke my fists when I raised them in
resistance
Blackened my eyes when they witnessed your
injustice
Shattered my knees when they knelt in earnest
And shot my heart when it felt the pain of the millions
you've oppressed
When we first met, I saw the dreams that you had
of justice pour out of your mouth like crashing waves
Hopes of freedom and equality collided through the
air.
You said it would always be us,
we the people.
I thought we were the perfect union
But how could we be perfect
When the gifts you gave me were stolen?
The labor of the Black slave
The land of the Native Americans
The freedom of the imprisoned Japanese

4NG Fanatics

The dreams of the undocumented immigrant
On our 13th date you promised things
would be different
That you would finally learn how to love me.
But your love affair with shackles and chains
is far from over
You just gave it a different name.
Told me I deserved it because I broke your rules
That I took the wrong steps
That I was in the wrong place at the wrong time
That I didn't even deserve to be here
Dear America,
How am I supposed to win your game
When you decided I would lose before I could even
play. . .

Dear America,
You were never great, you just told a great story
One I hope comes true.
But until it does,
I'll be standing here, being your guiding light.

Your Lady always,
Liberty

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Lydia Mason
Weblink: **https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=-f5PBBF8xj0**
ISBN: On-line Transcript
Publisher: New York University
Date (Month/Year): 2019
** Winner of the NYU's Constitution Day Slam 2018*

AWARD HISTORY

2025 National Qualifier - MS

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY